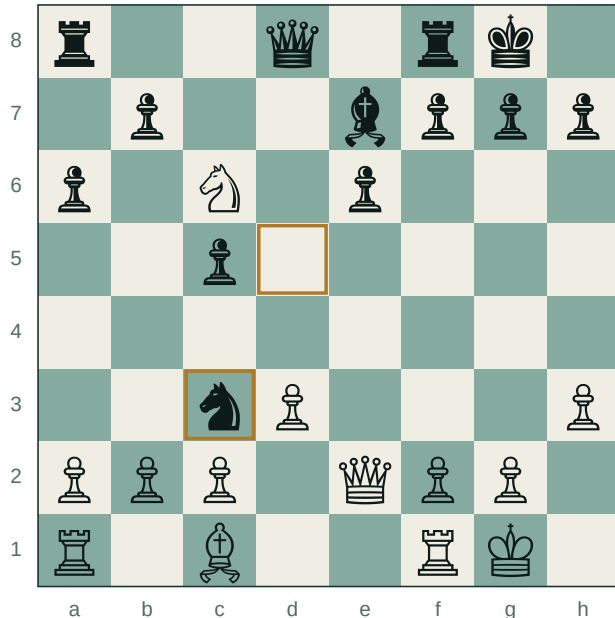


Intermediate moves: White, move 16

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 15...Nxc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. Nxe7+ Qxe7 17. bxc3

16.Nxe7+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on e7. Recorded reply: **16...Qxe7**.

17.bxc3 The pawn captures the knight on c3.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: knight on c3. Check for tactical protection.